

RULES OF PARALLEL CONSTRUCTION

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BASICS

1. Using Nouns

Incorrect: We can have **either** pizza **or** eating dosa

Correct: We can have **either** pizza **or** dosa

BASICS

2. Using Verbs

Incorrect: You can **either** join the club **or** staying home.

Correct: You can **either** join the club **or** stay at home.

BASICS

3. Using Adjectives

Incorrect: The movie was **either long or it was boring.**

Correct: The movie was **either long or boring.**

1. Elements in a Series or List (X, Y, and Z)

When listing three or more items, all items must share the same grammatical structure. The entire construction must be consistent.

Rule: Match **nouns with nouns, adjectives with adjectives, infinitives with infinitives, gerunds with gerunds, prepositional phrases with prepositional phrases**, and so on.

Common Error: Mixing verb forms (gerunds and infinitives) or mixing parts of speech (nouns and clauses).

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She enjoys reading, to write, and painting.

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The goal is to improve clarity, balance, and memorability. ✅

2. Paired Elements Joined by Coordinating Conjunctions

Coordinating conjunctions (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) join grammatically equal elements. The structure immediately preceding the conjunction must match the structure immediately following it.

Rule: If the first element is a noun phrase, the second must also be a noun phrase. If the first is an adjective, the second must also be an adjective.

2. Paired Elements Joined by Coordinating Conjunctions

He was an outspoken man but who was also kind.

2. Paired Elements Joined by Coordinating Conjunctions

He was a courageous man but **who was also kind.** ❌

2. Paired Elements Joined by Coordinating Conjunctions

He was an outspoken man but **who was also kind**. ❌

He was an outspoken man but a kind one. ✅

2. Paired Elements Joined by Coordinating Conjunctions

The proposal was lucid and it was comprehensive.

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The proposal was lucid and it was comprehensive. ❌

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The proposal was lucid and it was comprehensive. ❌

The proposal was lucid and comprehensive ✅

3. Elements Joined by Correlative Conjunctions

Correlative conjunctions are pairs that connect balanced sentence elements. The structure immediately following the first part of the pair must match the structure immediately following the second part.

Correlative Conjunctions:

- not only... but also
- either... or
- neither... nor
- both... and
- whether... or

not only... but also

She wants not only wealth but also to be happy.

not only... but also

She wants not only wealth but also to be happy.

not only... but also

She wants not only **wealth** but also **to be happy**.



not only... but also (nouns matching)

- She wants not only **wealth** but also **to be happy**.
- She wants not only **wealth** but also **happiness**.



not only... but also

- She wants not only **wealth** but also **to be happy**.
- She wants not only **wealth** but also **happiness**. 
- She not only wants wealth but also happiness.??

not only... but also

- She wants not only **wealth** but also **to be happy**.
- She wants not only **wealth** but also **happiness**.
- She not only wants wealth but also happiness.??
- She not only **wants wealth** but also **happiness**.??

not only... but also

- She wants not only **wealth** but also **to be happy**.
- She wants not only **wealth** but also **happiness**.
- She not only wants wealth but also happiness.??
- She not only **wants wealth** but also **happiness**.??
- She not only **wants wealth** but also **needs** happiness.

not only... but also

- She wants not only **wealth** but also **to be happy**.
- She wants not only **wealth** but also **happiness**.
- She not only wants wealth but also happiness.??
- She not only **wants wealth** but also **happiness**.??
- She not only **wants wealth** but also **needs** happiness



either... or

I prefer to go either to the library or studying at home.

either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.

either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.

either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.
(a prepositional phrase) (a gerund phrase)

either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.???

- I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** to the café. 
- I prefer to go **either** to the library or to my home. 
- I prefer either **to study** at the library or **to stay** at home. 
- I prefer either **to study** at the library or **to relax** at the cafe. 

either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.???

• I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** to the café.



either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.???

- I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** to the café.
- I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** to my home.



either... or

I prefer to go **either** to the library **or** studying at home.???

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neither... nor

- Neither is he a good dancer nor a proficient singer.

neither... nor

- Neither **is he** a good dancer nor a proficient singer.

neither... nor

- Neither **is he** a good dancer nor a proficient singer.
- He is **neither** a good dancer **nor** a proficient singer.

both ... and - 1

She is interested both in geography and history.???

both ... and - 1

- She is interested both in geography and history.???
- She is interested **both in** geography **and** history. 

both ... and - 1

- She is interested both in geography and history.???
- She is interested **both in** geography **and** history. 
- She is interested both **in geography** and **in history**. 

both ... and - 1

- She is interested both in geography and history.???
- She is interested **both in** geography **and** history. 
- She is interested both **in geography** and **in history**. 
- She is interested **in both** geography **and** history. 

both ... and - 2

The candidate both is intelligent and hardworking.???

both ... and - 2

- The candidate both is intelligent and hardworking.???
- The candidate **both** **is** intelligent **and** hardworking. 

both ... and - 2

- The candidate both is intelligent and hardworking.???
- The candidate **both** **is** intelligent **and** hardworking. 
- The candidate **is** **both** intelligent **and** hardworking. 

whether...or: Imbalanced Phrases

- We discussed whether to buy a new car or fixing the old one.???

whether...or: Imbalanced Phrases

- We discussed whether to buy a new car or fixing the old one.???
- We discussed whether **to buy** a new car or **fixing** the old one. 

whether...or: Imbalanced Phrases

- We discussed whether to buy a new car or fixing the old one.???
- We discussed whether **to buy** a new car or **fixing** the old one. 
- We discussed **whether to buy** a new car **or to fix** the old one. 

whether...or: Imbalanced Clauses

- It depends on whether you study hard or luck favours you.???

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- It depends on **whether** you study hard **or** luck favours you.



whether...or: Imbalanced Clauses

- It depends on whether you study hard or luck favours you.???
- It depends on **whether** you study hard **or** luck favours you. 
- It depends on **whether** **you** study hard **or** **you** rely on luck. 

4. Elements in a Comparison or Contrast

- When making a comparison using words like **than** or **as**, the two items being compared must have the same grammatical form.
- **Rule:** Match the structure before the comparison word (**than/as**) with the structure after it.

4. Elements in a Comparison or Contrast

- When making a comparison using words like **than** or **as**, the two items being compared must have the same grammatical form.
- **Rule:** Match the structure before the comparison word (**than/as**) with the structure after it.
- To read a book is better than watching a movie.???

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- **Reading** a book is better than **watching** a movie. 

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- Her job is more rewarding than my sister. ???

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- **Her job** is more rewarding **than** **my sister**. ❌
- **Her job** is more rewarding **than** **my sister's (job)**. ✅

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- I am as good at public speaking as giving presentations.??

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- I am **as** good at public speaking **as** giving presentations. 
- I am **as** good at public speaking **as** I am at giving presentations. 
- I am **as** good at public speaking **as** at giving presentations. 

5. Logical Parallelism

- This means the elements must not only match grammatically but also be logically comparable.

5. Logical Parallelism

- **Faulty Logical Parallelism:**
- The company's decline was due to poor management, outdated products, and the economy had shifted.



5. Logical Parallelism

Faulty Logical Parallelism:

Example: The company's decline was due to poor management, outdated products, and the economy had shifted.

- **Analysis:** The first two items are Noun Phrases (causes/factors). The last is an Independent Clause. Even if we force a grammatical match (e.g., ...and a shifting economy), the inclusion of two internal company factors and one external macro-factor (the economy) might be considered weak parallelism if the intent is to list equally-weighted reasons for an internal failure.
- **Correction:** The company's decline was due to poor management, outdated products, and a lack of market foresight. (All are internal, controllable factors expressed as noun phrase).